

2. Programme Information

Click on the titles below to see the detailed information.



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Overview and Structure



You can explore programme and module information online.

Each year of an undergraduate degree is made up of 120 credits, which means that a BSc is awarded on the basis of 360 credits and an MSci degree is awarded on the basis of 480 credits.

An MSc degree is made up of 180 credits. Of those 180 credits, 120 credits are the taught component and 60 credits is the project component.

Programmes and Modules Handbook

Programme Structure



In each year of your programme you will undertake a set of modules. Each module is assigned a number of credits. The greater the number of credits a module carries, the higher its weighting and the more hours you will have to dedicate to it.

For a 20-credit module, you are expected to undertake 200 hours work. For a lecture-based module, this 200 hours would include the contact time spent in lectures, laboratories, etc.. The remainder of the hours are spent on private study and continuous assessment, e.g., writing up laboratory reports, completing tutorial problems and coursework, reading, and revising.

You will complete weighted assessments in each module, including coursework, exams, and projects. To pass a module, the weighted combination of your assessments needs to be at or above the pass mark. The undergraduate pass mark is 40. The postgraduate pass mark is 50.

The table below shows how module marks are normally classified for undergraduate and taught postgraduate programmes.

Module Mark	Undergraduate	Taught Postgraduate
70-100	Class 1	Distinction
60-69	Class 2.1	Merit
50-59	Class 2.2	Pass
40-49	Class 3	Soft Fail
0-39	Fail	Hard Fail

The combination of modules you undertake throughout the course will build your degree, and the marks you achieve will influence its award and classification.

The table below shows how the average weighted degree mark (i.e., the weighted average across all modules) is normally classified for undergraduate and taught postgraduate programmes. Note that the table shows provisional classifications because the award of all degrees is subject to students having successfully passed sufficient credits - it is not solely based on the average mark.

Average Weighted Degree Mark	Provisional Undergraduate Classification	Provisional Taught Postgraduate Classification
70-100	Class 1	Distinction
60-69	Class 2.1	Merit
50-59	Class 2.2	Pass
40-49	Class 3	Soft Fail
0-39	Fail	Hard Fail

Progression and Awarding



To progress to the next year of a programme, a student must have passed sufficient credits and have passed any compulsory modules listed in their degree regulations.

Undergraduate students must pass a minimum of 100 credits (out of 120) to progress to the next year of study.

Postgraduate students on an MSc programme are required to pass a minimum of 80 non-project module credits at the 50% pass mark, with no module mark lower than 40.



Failure to Achieve Sufficient Credit on an Undergraduate Programme

Students who fail to achieve sufficient credit in modules at the first attempt, have the right to one further opportunity for assessment.

Note that you are strictly limited to one opportunity to rectify a failure. Resit assessments take place in the Supplementary Assessment period in August of each year. The maximum mark for a module following successful re-assessment is capped at 40% for undergraduates in years 1 to 3, 50% for MSci/MEng students in year 4.

Some module are repeat-only. A repeat-only module is a module which, if not passed on the first attempt, must be repeated in full during the next academic year. In other words, a student must attend lectures again and pay fees again. There is no supplementary reassessment for repeat-only modules. Examples of repeat-only modules are final year projects and modules where assessment is based primarily on group work.

It possible that the School of Computer Science will recommend for you to repeat a module in the following academic year (rather than resitting the exam/assessment in August) or you might choose to do this yourself if you have failed a significant amount of modules. If you wish to repeat one of more modules, you have to request the repeat in writing by completing the required form and following the appropriate process. Repeating a module involves attending lectures again and as a result will require for you to pay tuition fees for that specific module a second time.

Students who fail to achieve credit in final year modules have the opportunity for one resit. This opportunity includes the Final Year Project, which can be repeated the following academic year.

If you have any questions about the required credit levels, resist or repeats, please contact the Education Support Office via [**ug-cs@contacts.bham.ac.uk**](mailto:ug-cs@contacts.bham.ac.uk)

Failure to Achieve Sufficient Credit on an Postgraduate Taught Programme

For students on MSc programmes, the module pass mark is 50%. Note that students are strictly limited to one opportunity to rectify a failure during the next resit period. Resit assessments take place in the Supplementary Assessment period in August of each year.

Some modules are repeat-only. A repeat-only module is a module which, if not passed on the first attempt, must be repeated in full during the next academic year. In other words, a student must attend lectures again and pay fees again. There is no supplementary reassessment for repeat-only modules. Examples of repeat-only modules are final year projects and modules where assessment is based primarily on group work.

If an MSc student receives a module mark between 40-49%, this will disallow the award of a Merit or Distinction. If an MSc student receives a module mark under 40% on their second attempt at passing a module, the module failure will result in the failure of the MSc programme.

MSc Projects commonly take place during the summer term of your Masters year. The pass mark for your MSc project is 50%. If you do not pass your MSc project on your first attempt, you have one opportunity to repeat the project on the next summer period.

If you have any questions about the required credit levels, resits or repeats, please contact the Education Support Office via msc-cs@contacts.bham.ac.uk

Examinations

The main exam period takes place during the Summer Term, usually in May and June. Exams can account for as much as 80% of a module mark. Please note that exam papers can sometimes change due to a change in the staff responsible for a module.

Resits

Students who fail to pass sufficient credits in first or second year modules at the first attempt, have the right to one further opportunity for assessment. These resits will typically, but not always, take the same form as the main assessment. Note that students are strictly limited to one opportunity to rectify a failure. Resits take place before the Autumn Term, usually in August. The maximum recorded mark for a module following successful re-assessment is limited to the pass mark for the module.

Please read the information below and the Frequently Asked Questions section carefully. If it is unclear or you do not understand, you should immediately contact csoffice@contacts.bham.ac.uk for clarification.

University General Exams information: [Exams](#) 

Marking and Quality Assurance

Examination scripts are, wherever possible, marked anonymously. Anonymous marking means staff do not know the name of the student responsible for a given piece of work. For some types of assignments, such as dissertations and presentations, anonymous marking is not feasible, hence other measures are employed. These other measures normally involve work being assessed by at least two members of staff.

Assessments that are not marked by two members of staff are moderated. Moderation is where an additional member of staff checks the marking for a sample of anonymous work, spanning the range of marks, and work that has failed to achieve a pass mark. This ensures that work has been assessed in accordance with all relevant assessment criteria. Samples of assessments and examination scripts are made available to External Examiners.

Late Penalties



The School of Computer Science operates late penalties according to an implementation of the University Code of Practice for Taught Programme and Module Assessment and Feedback.

The following rules apply to all modules unless specified in writing as part of the general information for the module.

1. By default and unless otherwise specified – **no** late submissions will be accepted for any submitted coursework.
2. If late submissions are allowed then a lateness penalty will be applied as follows: 5% per working day with a final cut off of 1 week after the submission date.

This assumes that you do not have any extenuating circumstances such as illness. If you do, then you should contact the **Wellbeing Team** and request either an extension or waiver.

A different policy might be applied for modules with large pieces of coursework, e.g., the Final Year Project. If this is the case then this will be specified in writing on the relevant Canvas page and module information.

Feedback



Feedback will normally be made available to students within 15 working days for mid-module assessments and 20 working days for all other assessments. The definition of working days excludes University Closed Days and holidays, such as Christmas and Easter.

Where technical reasons prohibit the turnaround of feedback or a module is exempted from the expectation, students will be notified of the expected return date.

Optional Modules



It is important to ensure that you choose the full number of optional modules each academic year. Doing so allows you to be registered for modules that provide the required number of credits for your programme of study.

You will receive communications from the School of Computer Science regarding the process for choosing optional modules. Please respond to these communication promptly, as not engaging process is an example of failing to show reasonable diligence towards your study.

If you have not attempted the required credits for your programme of study, this may impact your eligibility to be awarded a degree and/or contribute negatively to your degree classification.

Year in Industry



The School of Computer Science encourages all students to gain industrial experience as part of their programme. Students often undertake placements over the summer, but some programmes in the School of Computer Science involve a year in industry. If you are studying on a programme that does not include a Year in Industry, you can request a transfer to that variant. The transfer must be requested early in Year 2.

You will hear more about placements from the pre-Year in Industry Canvas page, which is set up each academic year for students who are eligible to take an Industrial Year in the following academic session. If you would like to know more, you can always get in touch with the current Year In Industry Tutor through the Education Support Office.

Study Abroad



If you are studying on a programme that does not include study abroad but which does have a study abroad variant, you can request a transfer to that variant. The transfer must be requested before the end of Week 3 of Year 2.

Students intending to spend their Year Abroad in a non-English speaking country are expected to take language modules in Year 1 and 2. Up to 20 credits can be taken in Year 1, up to 40 credits in Year 2. Any timetabling issues arising from these modules are the responsibility of the student studying them, not the School of Computer Science.

Year 3 consists of a 120-credit Study Abroad module. To proceed to Year 3, students must have an overall second year mark of 55% or more, no outstanding reassessments (resits or repeats), and demonstrable skill in all languages required to study abroad.

Students who have returned from study abroad in a non-English speaking country will be able to choose an additional 20 credits of language modules.

Years 2 and 3 form a single stage. The mark for this stage will be based on 80% from Year 2 and 20% from Year 3 (the study abroad year). The stage counts for 25% of the degree. Thus the overall average for the programme will be calculated as 20% from Year 2 (the normal second year), 5% from Year 3 (Study Abroad) and 75% from Year 4 (the normal final year).

A student who fails the Study Abroad module will be permitted to transfer to the non-study abroad variant of their programme.

For help finding a placement, you might like to consult the Director of Overseas Programmes in the School of Computer Science.

The School of Computer Science currently has exchange agreements with the following universities:

- Institut National des Sciences Appliquees de Lyon (France)
- Technische Universitat Darmstadt (Germany)
- Technische Universitat Dresden (Germany)

In addition, the University has non subject-specific exchange agreements with universities in Argentina, Australia, Brazil, Canada, Chile, Hong Kong, Japan, Korea, Mexico, New Zealand, Singapore, United States.

You can find more information about study abroad on the University's Study Abroad webpages.

Study Abroad Webpages: <https://www.birmingham.ac.uk/international/study-abroad/index.aspx> 

Degree Apprenticeship



Degree Apprenticeship students complete a final assessment known as the End Point Assessment (EPA) at the conclusion of their degree, typically following their final exams. The EPA is designed to confirm that apprentices have achieved the required competencies, both core and specialism, as outlined in the apprenticeship standard. The EPA consists of two key components:

1. Gateway Meeting

Held after apprentices have completed all taught elements of their degree, including their final year project. This meeting ensures that apprentices have met all core competencies and have successfully completed their project.

2. EPA Presentation

Apprentices present how they have demonstrated the required specialism competencies through their project, and explain how their work aligns with their company's business objectives. While the focus is on specialism, assessors may also explore the apprentice's broader experience.

EPA presentations are assessed by two independent assessors, one appointed by the apprentice's employer and one by the University. Results are communicated to apprentices no later than the release of their exam results.



Programme Transfers



Before considering a programme transfer, you should consult with your Personal Tutor.

If you would like to transfer programmes within the School of Computer Science, please complete a programme transfer form and send it to UG ug-cs@contacts.bham.ac.uk or MSc msc-cs@contacts.bham.ac.uk

If you would like to transfer to a programme outside the School of Computer Science, you will need to ask the school you are moving to to sign-off the form before completing the programme transfer form.

Programme Transfer Form: <https://intranet.birmingham.ac.uk/as/registry/studentrecords/services/programme-changes.aspx>

External Examiners



External Examiners play a critical role in supporting the maintenance of academic standards and overseeing assessment processes. External Examiners ensure that assessments are carried out fairly and consistently, and that standards are commensurate with other UK higher education institutions and/or with relevant professional standards.

Additional Costs and Resources



You are not expected to incur any additional costs as part of your programme of study.

The School of Computer Science maintains laboratories to make desktop machines available to all students. As such, no student is required to purchase a laptop or desktop machine to study in the School of Computer Science. However, most students do have a personal laptop to support their study. Having a laptop is extremely convenient for taking notes in lectures, working through laboratories and completing coursework.

Any student considering buying a laptop should note that it is not necessary for to have a particularly powerful or high-specification laptop. Almost any modern laptop will be sufficient. It does not matter whether a laptop runs the Linux, MacOS or Windows operating system, since each of these is commonplace in the School of Computer Science. Mobile phones, tablets and Chromebook are not appropriate primary devices when it comes to work through laboratories and completing coursework.

If any student is experiencing financial difficulties that impact on study, they should consider applying to the Student Support Fund. The Student Support Fund is provided by the University of Birmingham to help students who have genuine and unavoidable financial difficulties and are struggling with their basic living costs despite having received all the financial support available to them.

<https://www.birmingham.ac.uk/study/student-experience/advice-support/money-advice/student-support-fund> ➞

